

What is the continuum of actions we can take within the different strategies used to work on social problems?

The Social Problem Strategies Continuum (G19) sets out the five social problem strategies identified in the Initiative or Policy Strategy Selection Tool (B10). It is a blow-up of the bottom box in the Social Problem Solving Cycle (G18).

For each of the five strategies, there is a continuum of styles that can be used. For instance, regarding Monitoring and Regulatory Enforcement, these run from 'Raising awareness of regulatory requirements' to 'Proactive enforcement'.

Early steps on the continuum for each strategy meet less resistance from affected stakeholders than later steps. As illustrated in the Social Problem Solving Cycle (G18), there is a predictable pattern to attempts to fix social problems, which leads to the fact that they usually endure over time.

What usually happens when working on reducing a social problem is that resistance to the implementation of more effective steps leads to only low-resistance or administratively convenient styles of action. This Social Problem Strategies Continuum shows how effective action on social problems often involves moving along the continuum towards the styles of action that are more likely to bring about significant change.

As one moves downwards to select more challenging (but potentially more effective) strategies, thought needs to be put into what needs to be done to ensure that the particular style of action is sustained over time. This involves, for instance, pointing out the progress that is being made on the social problem by using more effective styles of action and embedding support for them among supportive stakeholders.